THE IVORY CRADLE SCHOOL · MILK HANDLING ON SHIFT

Milk Handling Decision Sheet

Storage times follow CDC. Clinical guidance from AAP. Routine care of healthy babies at home in the U.S.

1 BEFORE YOU OFFER ANY BOTTLE

Which baby is it for?
Check the name on the label when milk is stored for more than one child.

What does it contain?
Expressed breast milk or prepared formula. Each follows its own clock.

What is its handling history?
Expressed or prepared, frozen, thawed, warmed, offered at a feed.

2 QUICK REFERENCE · CDC TIMES TAUGHT IN THIS COURSE

Milk	Where and temperature	Limit	Notes
Fresh breast milk	Room temperature, 77°F or colder	Up to 4 hours	Label the date expressed (add the child's name for childcare). Store at the back, not the door. Not used within 4 days? Freeze right away. Oldest first.
	Refrigerator, 40°F or colder	Up to 4 days	
Frozen	Freezer, 0°F or colder	About 6 months best; up to 12 months acceptable	
Thawed	Refrigerator	Within 24 hours, counted from completely thawed	Thaw in the fridge, warm or lukewarm water, or lukewarm running water. Never microwave. Never refreeze thawed milk.
Warmed or room temp	Brought to room temperature or warmed	Within 2 hours	Can be served cold. Warm sealed, in warm water; test on wrist. Swirl to mix the fat.
Leftover after a feed	Baby did not finish	Within 2 hours after the baby finishes, then discard	AAP HealthyChildren also allows quick refrigeration for the next feeding; this course teaches CDC.
Prepared formula	Room temperature	2 hours from preparation and 1 hour from start of feed	Not started within 2 hours? Refrigerate right away, use within 24 hours. Discard what is left after the feed.

Combining, transport, power outage

- Cool fresh milk before adding it to chilled milk. The older milk's date sets the limit.
- Insulated cooler with frozen ice packs: up to 24 hours, then use, refrigerate, or freeze.
- After an outage: ice crystals still present, may refreeze. Fully thawed but cold, refrigerate and use within the next day or discard.

Formula

- Ready to feed: no water. Concentrate and powder: water exactly as the label says, water first, then powder.
- Under 2 months, born before 37 weeks, or weakened immune system: boil water, wait about 5 minutes, mix (about 158°F), cool, test on wrist.
- Clinician directed plan or special formula: follow it and the product directions.

3 PRACTICE · WEDNESDAY 2:00 A.M. (TEACHING EXAMPLE)

Family plan: offer expressed milk from the fridge, labeled milk only. If no labeled milk is usable, wake a parent.

Container	Decision	Rule I used
A Bag expressed Sunday, frozen, moved to fridge Monday night. Completely thawed Tue 4:00 p.m.	☐ Use ☐ Discard ☐ Set aside and verify	
B Bottle warmed 11:20 p.m. Baby fed until 11:45 p.m. On the nightstand since.	☐ Use ☐ Discard ☐ Set aside and verify	
C Bottle of milk in the fridge door, no label.	☐ Use ☐ Discard ☐ Set aside and verify	

What I would say to the parent in the morning

Sources (CDC is the named standard for storage times): CDC Breast Milk Storage and Preparation · CDC Breast Milk Storage Questions and Answers · CDC Infant Formula Preparation and Storage · AAP Milk Storage Guidelines · AAP HealthyChildren: Tips for Freezing and Refrigerating Breast Milk · AAP HealthyChildren: How to Safely Prepare Baby Formula With Water. Cases are fictional teaching examples. Premature, hospitalized, or medically vulnerable baby: follow the care team's plan. Formula: follow the product directions.